

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Project Management English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For project managers, program managers, PMO staff, scrum masters, delivery leads, operations managers, and cross-functional coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Defining the deliverable

02 A critical dependency

03 Risk or issue?

04 A scope change

05 An honest status report

06 Resource negotiation

07 Handover to operations

08 Lessons learned

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Defining the deliverable

A sponsor and project manager clarify a vague request.

Roles: Project manager / Project sponsor

Project manager: When you say a customer portal, which capabilities must be in the first release?

Project sponsor: Order status and document downloads. Payments can wait.

Project manager: Who will accept the deliverable, and against what criteria?

Project sponsor: Operations will confirm that customers can find their orders and approved documents.

Project manager: Let's make those acceptance criteria measurable before we baseline the scope.

Project sponsor: Include our service manager in that discussion.

Project manager: I'll document the exclusions and send the scope statement for review.

Project sponsor: Good. That should also make later change requests easier to evaluate.

Notice the professional language

acceptance criteria - Specific conditions a deliverable must meet to be accepted.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A critical dependency

A project schedule depends on an external interface.

Roles: Project manager / Technical lead

Project manager: The interface specification is two weeks late. Does that move the critical path?

Technical lead: Yes. Integration testing depends on it, and there's no remaining float on that sequence.

Project manager: Can any work proceed independently?

Technical lead: We can build test fixtures against the draft, but rework remains possible.

Project manager: Give me that option with its assumptions and effort.

Technical lead: I'll also identify what the supplier must confirm before testing can start.

Project manager: I'll escalate the dependency to the sponsor.

Technical lead: Keep the current delivery date marked at risk until the schedule is reassessed.

Notice the professional language

critical path - Sequence of dependent work that determines the shortest feasible timeline.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Risk or issue?

A team reviews a late permit in its project register.

Roles: Project coordinator / Project manager

Project coordinator: The permit was due yesterday and hasn't arrived. Is it still just a risk?

Project manager: The missed milestone is now an issue. Further schedule impact is still uncertain.

Project coordinator: Should I close the original risk entry?

Project manager: Link it to the issue so we preserve the history and response plan.

Project coordinator: Who owns the follow-up?

Project manager: The permitting lead. Ask for the current status and expected decision window.

Project coordinator: I'll record the next review date and the affected activities.

Project manager: Good. Don't assign a revised completion date without checking those dependencies.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The permit was due yesterday and hasn't arrived. Is it still just a risk?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A scope change

A stakeholder requests a new dashboard during delivery.

Roles: Business owner / Project manager

Business owner: Can you add regional filters before launch? It sounds like a small change.

Project manager: It may be useful, but we need to assess data, testing, and schedule effects.

Business owner: Could we trade out the export feature?

Project manager: That's an option. The change request should compare both combinations.

Business owner: I can explain which business need is more urgent.

Project manager: I'll get an effort estimate and submit the options to the change authority.

Business owner: So it isn't included yet?

Project manager: Correct. We'll update the approved scope and plan after the decision.

Notice the professional language

change request - A proposal to alter an agreed product, scope, schedule, or process.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

An honest status report

A sponsor questions a green status indicator.

Roles: Sponsor / Project manager

Sponsor: Why is the project green when user testing hasn't started?

Project manager: You're right to question it. The report didn't reflect the new test-data delay.

Sponsor: What does that mean for the milestone?

Project manager: It's at risk. We haven't quantified the full effect yet.

Sponsor: Then tell the steering group what decision you need.

Project manager: I'll show the dependency, two recovery options, and the date we need an answer.

Sponsor: Make the reporting period explicit too.

Project manager: I'll correct the status and circulate the revised report before the meeting.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Why is the project green when user testing hasn't started?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Resource negotiation

Two project managers need the same specialist.

Roles: Project manager / Resource manager

Project manager: I need the security architect for five days next week.

Resource manager: She's already allocated to an incident review. Which tasks truly require her?

Project manager: The threat-model review and design signoff. Documentation could be prepared by our analyst.

Resource manager: Could two focused review sessions cover the immediate need?

Project manager: Possibly, if the analyst completes the evidence pack first.

Resource manager: I'll ask the architect to assess that plan before changing her allocation.

Project manager: I'll send the decisions and preparation required for each session.

Resource manager: Then we can confirm a feasible commitment and flag any remaining gap.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "She's already allocated to an incident review. Which tasks truly require her?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Handover to operations

The delivery team prepares to transfer a service.

Roles: Delivery manager / Operations lead

Delivery manager: The build is complete. Are you ready to accept the service?

Operations lead: Not yet. The runbook lacks escalation contacts, and support training is incomplete.

Delivery manager: Let's distinguish technical completion from operational acceptance.

Operations lead: Exactly. We also need the outstanding defect list and monitoring arrangements.

Delivery manager: I'll assign owners and dates to those handover items.

Operations lead: I'll review the completed evidence against our acceptance checklist.

Delivery manager: Can we schedule the acceptance meeting provisionally?

Operations lead: Yes, provided the invitation makes clear that approval is still pending.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The build is complete. Are you ready to accept the service?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Lessons learned

A project team reviews a missed milestone.

Roles: Project manager / Workstream lead

Project manager: What contributed to the missed milestone beyond the supplier delay?

Workstream lead: We didn't verify the dependency early enough, and the escalation route was unclear.

Project manager: What change would help the next project?

Workstream lead: A dependency review at kickoff with named owners and trigger dates.

Project manager: Who can put that into the standard planning checklist?

Workstream lead: The delivery office. I'll draft the addition for its review.

Project manager: Let's record the action and a check that it was adopted.

Workstream lead: Agreed. A lesson isn't useful if it stays only in these minutes.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What contributed to the missed milestone beyond the supplier delay?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Project Charter and Scope Definition

SHARED CASE

A sponsor requests a dashboard but the brief does not define users, decisions, or excluded features.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Who will use the dashboard, and what decision should it support? Let's agree on those needs and the exclusions before we estimate the work or call the scope complete.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Schedule, Critical Path, and Dependencies

SHARED CASE

A testing task is three days late and blocks the release rehearsal. Other work is on schedule.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

Testing is three days late and is blocking the release rehearsal. Other tasks remain on schedule. I'll show the dependency and the proposed recovery options in the schedule update.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Risk Register and Issue Escalation

SHARED CASE

A risk register still lists a supplier delay as a possibility, although the supplier has confirmed it will miss the delivery date.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The delay is now a confirmed issue, not only a future risk. I'll update its status and ask the responsible owner to document the impact and next action.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Stakeholder Alignment and Governance

SHARED CASE

A project meeting ends with several recommendations but no indication of who approves the change.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

We have a recommendation, but approval is still outstanding. Who has authority to approve this change, and what information do they need? I'll record the decision route in the meeting notes.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Change Requests and Scope Creep

SHARED CASE

A sponsor asks for a new report two weeks before launch. The team can add it only by moving another feature or extending the schedule.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

We can assess the new report as a scope change. To include it, we would need to move another feature or extend the schedule. Which tradeoff should we develop for review?

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Status Reporting and Executive Updates

SHARED CASE

A project is labeled green despite an unresolved dependency that threatens its planned date. The reporting criteria require material threats to be visible.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The current label does not show the unresolved dependency. I'll report the delivery threat, its impact, and the decision needed so the status reflects the agreed criteria.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Vendor and Cross-Functional Delivery

SHARED CASE

A vendor says a deliverable is complete, but the team cannot find evidence for two acceptance criteria.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you provide the evidence for these two criteria or identify any outstanding work? We need to review the deliverable against the agreed criteria before confirming acceptance.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Post-Implementation Review

SHARED CASE

A project review repeatedly says "communication was poor." The team has no concrete improvement action.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed ...

The effect was ... What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which message or handoff caused difficulty, and what happened as a result? Let's turn that example into a specific change, assign an owner, and decide how we will check whether it helped.

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.